BJP ministers in the state (four of five) came from either the Congress, the Trinamool Congress or the National People's Party (NPP).[84] In fact, the entire Manipur unit of P.A. Sangma's NPP defected to the BJP.[85] Similarly, the party's lone minister in Meghalaya, Alexander Laloo Hek, who became the leader of its legislator party and a cabinet minister holding several portfolios, was a former Congress minister.[86] He too defected to the party just a month before the state elections, along with other legislators.

Arunachal Pradesh was a separate category of defections altogether. Here, the BJP won the entire state through defections in 2016. It started when Chief Minister Pema Khandu, then with the Congress, defected with forty-three party MLAs to join the People's Party of Arunachal and formed a new government in September 2016.[87] Three months later, in December 2016, he defected to the BJP with thirty-two MLAs to form a new government in Itanagar.[88] It was another three years before he formed the BJP's first 'elected' government in Arunachal, in 2019—'elected' in the sense that he fought the 2019 state assembly elections for the first time as a BJP man, campaigned on the party banner, asked for votes in its name and won a full majority.

## *Strategy 2: Strategic Alliances, Co-option and Partnerships*

### NEDA AS AN ANTI-CONGRESS ALLIANCE UMBRELLA

The BJP's second big pillar of growth in the Northeast was the creation of a network of alliances with regional parties, aimed at replacing the Congress in the region. The first step towards this was the formation of the NEDA coalition in 2016. Launched a day after the BJP's first Assam government was sworn in to office, with a meeting of regional chief ministers and the enunciation of what was called the Guwahati Declaration, NEDA was kicked off with the slogan of a 'Congress-mukt North-East'. As NEDA Convenor Himanta Biswa Sarma explained, the coalition's aim was the 'expansion of the base of BJP and its NE allies to make a Congress-free region at the local or regional level'.[89] It was also meant to 'institutionalise broader political cooperation' as 'not just a political